



Early success: Anderson Peters, Curtis Thompson and Tyriq Horsford completed a podium sweep for Mississippi State at the 2019 NCAA Division I Outdoor Track & Field Championships. Pics: GETTY IMAGES

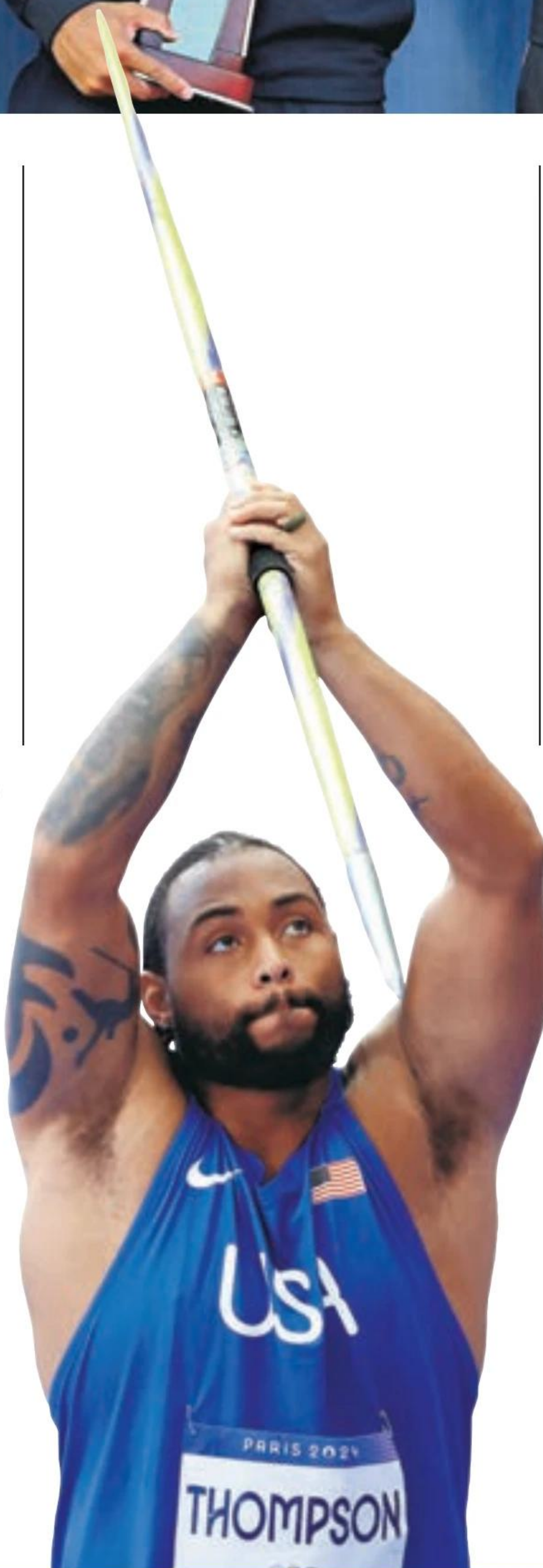
come to a point where our top athletes can just train and compete.”

Fortunately, his secondary vocation keeps him connected to his passion. As an athletics coach at Spain Park High School in Alabama, Thompson finds renewal in teaching the sport to others.

“Coaching kids reminds you of some of the basics that you tend to forget by the time you get to that top level. Also, there’s a type of joy in coaching the youth and watching their passion grow for something that you’ve learned to grow, love and enjoy.”

That joy comes at a cost. Coaching eats into his training, and he has to fine-tune his routine to stay aligned with his javelin goals.

High on that list is the Los Angeles Games. The USA’s last Olympic javelin medal came in 1972 — a bronze for Bill Schmidt. “I am excited for 2028. That’s going to be a big one. And to have the opportunity to win a medal in the US is



something I’m looking forward to.”

Also within reach is the 90m mark — a distance only one American, Breau Greer (PB: 91.29m, Indianapolis, 2007), has ever surpassed.

But beyond medals and milestone throws, Thompson’s ultimate goal is bigger. “One of the things that I want is to have the US pop up in conversation whenever anybody talks about javelin. I also hope that by the time I’m done, the US javelin standard rises.

“We need guys who are striving not just for the 80-metre mark, but go beyond that. So, if I can do that, then I’ll be satisfied, even if I don’t get a medal or anything. But of course, would love to win a few.”

Next up is his first trip to India, for the Neeraj Chopra Classic in July — another country added to a globe-trotting career that still surprises him.

“Javelin has taken me to so many places that I never would have. I think if you pick up a sport and get to this level, it will help you see the world while doing your job. There have been plenty of places that I’ve gone to and realised, ‘I probably never would have been here if I wasn’t throwing a javelin,’” says Thompson.